

sions, too. Twenty percent off. Not on everything but on some things. On the options, definitely.”

Seeing no point in continuing this conversation, since I’d vowed never again to play with options, I got up from my swivel chair and prepared to leave. That two other people were waiting to see the broker of the day made it easier to get away. I could tell that Mr. Nemerov saw the couple out of the corner of his eye. “Come back anytime,” he said, escorting me toward the door. “Feel free to call back and ask questions.” With that, we shook hands and I left.

From Thomson McKinnon, I headed out to Sears. Halfway between the perfumes and the vacuum cleaners was the Dean Witter counter. Here I found a broker named Ralph. He, too, looked 25, and I think he wore a suit that came from the store. Like Mr. Nemerov, Ralph mentioned he’d been in the business a few weeks, but the big difference was his humility. He said he didn’t feel qualified to recommend individual stocks, and would only go so far as to suggest the Ginnie Mae Fund for income and the Dean Witter Dividend Growth mutual fund for capital appreciation, with lower sales charges the longer you hold on to it.

I asked Ralph to check on the current price of Texaco on the Quotron machine behind the counter. After struggling with the keyboard for several minutes, he admitted he hadn’t gotten the hang of the Quotron. Then he described the migratory patterns of Dean Witter brokers, which I found fascinating. The newest and greenest among them start out at the airports, selling financial services between flights. If they do well at the airports, they’re sent to the Sears stores to learn a bit more, and only after they’ve succeeded at Sears are they finally assigned to regular Dean Witter offices. Ralph gets the credit for my Seventh Useful Tip:

Never buy anything from a broker at an airport

Although I admired Ralph for his humility and for his caution, I could see that neither would get him very far in this business, and I crossed him off my list immediately. Meanwhile, Ralph must have sensed what I’d been thinking because he underwent a re-